months to complete, my team can do it within much less time, thanks to open source technologies. The other advantage is that the support for this technology is really high. Let's say we are using a certain technology and get stuck at some point. There are enough people in the community willing to guide us—those who have already gone through the same problem and have a solution ready. This cuts down a lot on the time we would have spent to get to the bottom of the problem. So community support is the second major advantage that we get with open source technologies.

While open source software is well supported by the community, there are no restrictions on how you use it. You can always take out a piece of open source software, modify it to suit your needs, and use it the way you want. In case of proprietary software, you cannot touch anything because you don't have the source code in most cases. If one requires any changes in the proprietary software, one has to place a request and wait for the approval to arrive. So, there is an issue with proprietary software vis a vis open source technologies.

Q Does talent continue to be an issue when it comes to working on open source technologies?

Not really. There are two aspects to getting the right talent. One is, getting talent to work on specific technologies. This is difficult, unless it is something as popular as Java. However, having said that, there is enough material available on open source. So, as long as I am able to find an engineer who has the ability to grasp such technologies quickly by reading the material available, and is ready to experiment and ramp up quickly, specially in open source skills, I would be happy to hire him or her. For example, if we take the graph database, Neo4J, there is enough content and study material available for it. Just type 'Neo4J' in any search engine and you will probably get hundreds and thousands of pages. So the risk of not finding a person who has worked on a particular platform reduces significantly.

Q Do you get the right kind of talent all the time or do you have to train people in-house?

When we look for talent, we do not necessarily look for talent on a particular technology unless it is something like .NET. What we look for is people who have the ability to ramp up quickly and who have the passion to be able to deliver fast. That is my primary concern when I hire someone. As an organisation, we have a large learning and development (L&D) team, which comes under the recruitment function. We have regular training sessions within the organisation. So, getting someone from within the company to work on a certain technology is easier than hiring someone from outside. However, our core functions are based on Java and getting Java professionals nowadays is not that difficult.

Q What are the challenges you face with open source technologies?

The primary challenge with open source technologies is not being entirely certain about support. What if the support for a certain technology is withdrawn? A few years back there was a framework for PHP. We started using it, and suddenly we heard that support for that framework had been stopped. Instead, they had started advocating Zend. So we had to give up on that technology and go forward with something more stable. This is one risk that comes with open source technologies.

The other thing is, while you can use open source, there is no accountability for it. If you are using a technology which is pretty new to the system and a problem occurs, then there is nobody to account for it. Let's say there is a bug in the system or a loophole, which may come out only under specific use cases. We have to work to patch that, else it can affect our production environment badly. In case of proprietary systems, there is some accountability, for sure.

While security is very high in open source because a lot of people work on it and usually the bugs are located early, there is also a risk that a lot of people know the technology, inside out. If they know what systems I am using, they can exploit a vulnerability that I don't know about.

Q When did your tryst with open source technology begin?

I have officially been a Java guy throughout. In my previous organisation, which was in the telecom domain, I used to write software in Java. Then I moved to Ibibo, where most of the software was being built on Java or PHP. In redBus, when I came in, a part of the system was on .NET and the remaining on Java. Some of these were moved completely onto open source. Our inventory platform is completely on open source right now, while our consumer-facing website, redBus.in, is still on .NET. It's an older system and we would like to go slow with that. Also, we have enough people to manage that system. So, we don't necessarily need to go and change that to open source unless there is a requirement for it.

Q So, if you had to develop an application afresh, today, would open source technology be your first option?

I prefer going the open source way, personally. My recommendation is always to look for a solution that is available on an open source platform, and to check the level of support being offered there. If there is something which is apt and is available in open source, we prefer using that. Apart from getting a lot of community support and other such benefits, there are definitely a lot of cost benefits that an organisation can enjoy, which is really important for us. There are two kinds of costs involved—the development cost and the deployment cost. If I use proprietary software and require some proprietary tools for development, there is a cost involved in that. If there is a licence attached to it, that is an additional recurring cost for running the application. From a cost benefit perspective, I would like to go for open source.

Q What matters to you more—a solution or an open source solution?

I think a good solution matters to me the most. The solution should be scalable. Whether it is built on proprietary technology or open source technology doesn't really matter to me at the CTO level. But, from a personal preference perspective, I would choose an open source solution, any day. As I said, there are a lot of cost benefits that come with open source technologies. END